

Notes on Distributions, Sobolev Spaces and Weak Solutions

Written by: Caio Giroldo Valério

The main objective of this text is to compile everything I've read or discussed about weak solutions on PDEs and the prerequisites for understanding this topic.

Summary

1	Motivation	3
2	Test functions and Distributions	5
2.1	The elements of $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ and $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$	5
2.2	Distributional derivatives	6

CHAPTER 1

Motivation

We will begin by studying the solution of the following equation:

$$u_t + uu_x = 0, \text{ for } x \in \mathbb{R} \text{ and } t > 0 \quad (1)$$

This is commonly known as the inviscid Burger's equation, a simplified model for fluid mechanics, modelling one dimensional flow where $u(x, t)$ is the velocity of the particle located in x at time t . So, first, we are going to try to find regular solutions for this equation by the method of characteristics.

Considering $u(x, t)$ to be a smooth solution for (1) satisfying the initial condition problem:

$$u(x, 0) = u_0(x)$$

Where $u_0(x)$ is a function of x . We'll start by defining the characteristic curves:

$$\begin{cases} \dot{x}(t) = u(x(t), t), & x(0) = x_0 \\ \dot{y}(t) = 1, & y(0) = y_0 \end{cases}$$

Solely from that, we get $y = t$. And now, by calculating the total derivative of u on the curves just defined, we obtain:

$$\frac{du}{dt} = \frac{\partial u}{\partial t} \frac{\partial y}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial u}{\partial x} \frac{\partial x}{\partial t} = u_t + u_x u = 0$$

From this, two conclusions are made: u is constant along the curve $(x(t), t)$, which implies that $\dot{x}(t) = u_0(x_0)$. By solving this last ODE, we conclude that:

$$x = x_0 + u_0(x_0)t$$

And for all points in this curve $u(x, t) = u_0(x_0)$. For convenience's sake, we will choose this as our initial curve u_0 :

Using the initial condition given by u_0 , the characteristic curves are:

We can clearly see that there are curves intersecting each other, so the value of $u(x, t)$ is not well-defined at the intersection points, therefore this cannot be a solution for our equation.

Now, the question that rises is: "if that isn't a solution, then what is?". And that will motivate our next few chapters of functional analysis definitions and theorems, aiming to build a generalized perspective on what is a solution for a PDE.

CHAPTER 2

Test functions and Distributions

Our main objective in this chapter is to make useful definitions to generalize the derivative of a function. For that, we will need a mechanism that can weaken the conditions for a function to have partial derivatives, by removing it entirely and passing it to another convenient function that always has a derivative in any axis.

2.1 The elements of $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ and $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$

Definition 2.1: Test functions

Let Ω be a subset of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ is the set of all C^∞ functions defined on Ω with compact support.

An example of such function is:

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \exp(\frac{-a^2}{a^2-x^2}), & |x| < a \\ 0, & |x| \geq a \end{cases}$$

And, for any φ on this set and any locally integrable function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, using integration by parts we get:

$$\int_K D^\alpha f \varphi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int_K f D^\alpha \varphi \quad (2)$$

Where $K \supseteq \text{supp} \varphi$ is a compact subset of Ω and α is a multi-index. This will motivate our next definition, but before that, we need to quickly describe the topology of $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$:

A sequence $\{\varphi_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ in $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ converges to φ if there exists a compact set $K \subset \Omega$ such that $\text{supp}(\varphi_n) \subset K$ for all n and $D^\alpha \varphi_n \rightarrow D^\alpha \varphi$ for all α .

Now we can define the most important tool used in this endeavour:

Definition 2.2: Distributions

A linear functional T is said to be a distribution if for all sequences $\{\varphi_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ in $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ convergent to φ , the sequence $\{T\varphi_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ converges to $T\varphi$ in $\mathbb{R}$.

We will use $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ for the set of all distributions. Note that $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ uses the same notation as the dual space of $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ and that is no coincidence, as the distributions are precisely the dual elements of the test functions, as they are the linear functionals defined from $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ to $\mathbb{R}$. Furthermore, it is worth to point that both $\mathcal{D}(\Omega)$ and $\mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$ are vector spaces over $\mathbb{R}$.

Now, aiming for (2), we will define the following:

Definition 2.3: Distribution given by a function

Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a locally integrable function, we say that the distribution given by f is:

$$T_f(\varphi) = \int_{\Omega} f \varphi$$

It is trivial to verify that T_f is in fact a distribution, because as $\varphi_n \rightarrow \varphi$, $\int_{\Omega} f \varphi_n \rightarrow \int_{\Omega} f \varphi$.

Another useful distribution is the Dirac "δ-function", which is in fact a distribution given by:

Definition 2.4: The Dirac distribution

For any $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega)$:

$$\delta(\varphi) = \varphi(0)$$

These both distributions will be essential for the next sections.

2.2 Distributional derivatives

Having (2) in mind, let's build a definition of a distribution derivative that can satisfy that equation. Let f be a smooth function in Ω , so:

$$D^{\alpha} T f(\varphi) = D^{\alpha} \int_{\Omega} f \varphi$$

Now, by the dominated convergence theorem we can push the derivative inside the integral, that is:

$$D^{\alpha} \int_{\Omega} f \varphi = \int_{\Omega} D^{\alpha} f \varphi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int_{\Omega} f D^{\alpha} \varphi$$

So, we now know what we have to define $D^{\alpha} T$ as to serve our needs. We let f as a smooth function just so $D^{\alpha} f$ has some meaning in a sense, but in general, the only condition f must abide is to be locally integrable.

Definition 2.5: Derivative of a distribution

Let $T \in \mathcal{D}'(\Omega)$, the α derivative of T is:

$$D^\alpha T(\varphi) = (-1)^{|\alpha|} T(D^\alpha \varphi)$$

Another important thing to note is that, for a distribution given by a function f , the following identity is verified:

Lemma 2.1

$$D^\alpha T_f(\varphi) = T_{D^\alpha f} = (-1) T_f(D^\alpha \varphi)$$

Which was already proven before. In addition to that, we will say that a locally integrable function f has a distributional derivative if there exists a distribution G such that for all $\varphi \in \mathcal{D}(\Omega)$:

$$\frac{d}{dt} T_f(\varphi) = G(\varphi)$$

So G is the distributional derivative of f . If $G = T_g$ for some locally integrable function g , then we also say that g is the distributional derivative of f . This distributional derivative is also what is called the weak derivative of f , sometimes denoted as $\partial_t f$.

It should be clear that if a function has a regular derivative, its weak derivative will be the same, as the identity above will be satisfied by:

$$\frac{d}{dt} T_f = T_{\frac{df}{dt}}$$

Example 2.1: The derivative of the Heaviside Function

The Heaviside function is defined as:

$$H(x) \begin{cases} 1, x \geq 0 \\ 0, x < 0 \end{cases}$$

So the distributional derivative of H is the δ distribution.

Proof. Let $\Omega \in \mathbb{R}$. As H is a locally integrable function, let's evaluate the distribution given by H :

$$T_H(\varphi) = \int_{\Omega} H(x) \varphi(x) dx$$

So, by taking the derivative of this distribution and using lemma 2.1 we get:

$$\frac{d}{dx} T_H(\varphi) = -T_H\left(\frac{d\varphi}{dx}\right) = - \int_0^{+\infty} H(x) \frac{d\varphi}{dx} dx = \varphi(x) \Big|_0^{+\infty} = \varphi(0) = \delta(\varphi)$$

Therefore, δ is the distributional derivative of the Heaviside function. ■